RESET PAGE

## Opportunities

1. Identify a situation in which increased Conversational Capacity would improve the effectiveness of your team.

## Gaining Perspective on Your Challenging Conversation

Consider the challenging conversation you identified in your LAUNCH assignment and answer the following questions:

2. What do you expect the other people involved in the challenging conversation will think about the problem and how to address it?

3. What information might be missing, or unclear, and who else could provide a helpful perspective?

## Trigger Inventory

To create a trigger inventory, check the triggers listed below that affect your ability to remain in the sweet spot of a conversation.

- [ ] Authority
- [ ] Expertise
- [ ] Personality
- [ ] Disrespect
- [ ] Reputation
- [ ] Fatigue
- [ ] Stress

Additional Triggers

## Self-Awareness

Raise your awareness of your natural tendencies by answering the questions below.

4. Under what circumstances are you most triggered to Minimize or Win?

5. What about you might trigger others to leave the sweet spot?

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RESET PAGE

## Trigger Journal

| What was the situation? | What was the trigger? | How did it affect my behavior? | What would have been a better way to respond? |
|---|---|---|---|
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RESET PAGE

## Team Volker

How did Toni's reaction to Volker's objections affect his behavior?

What impact did Volker's behavior have on the quality of the discussion?

Which of the three questions for maintaining a learning-focused mindset would have been most helpful to Volker?

- [ ] What am I seeing that others are missing?
- [ ] What are others seeing that I am missing?
- [ ] What are we all missing?



## Team Toni

What was Toni's goal for the conversation?

How did Toni respond to Volker's concerns?

What impact did Toni's behavior have on the quality of the discussion?

Which of the three questions for maintaining a learning-focused mindset would have been most helpful to Toni?

- [ ] What am I seeing that others are missing?
- [ ] What are others seeing that I am missing?
- [ ] What are we all missing?



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RESET PAGE

## Speaking with Candor

Use the information below to help Volker share his concerns candidly.

***Volker's Point of View***

Your manager has just proposed a new configuration for the shop-floor equipment to make production more efficient. She wants to connect the stamping press to the new sorting machine. The materials going into the stamping press come directly out of heated molds. You estimate the parts will still be around 400 degrees Fahrenheit. The sorting machine oriented the parts so they are face up for additional processing. It operates at high speed and the friction generated in the process creates additional heat. Excess heat in the system can cause jamming, damage the machine, or worse yet, spark a fire. There are any number of variables that should be investigated and tested before attempting this configuration.

Other team members are quick to get on board with the idea, so you are going to need to express your concerns candidly.

Write a clear, concise, and compelling position statement for Volker:

In the shaded box above, circle or highlight the thinking that supports the position you created.

## Your Position and Thinking

1. Consider the challenging conversation you identified in the LAUNCH assignment. Script a clear, concise, and compelling position statement for the conversation.

2. Outline a brief script that explains the thinking that supports your position statement.

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RESET PAGE

## Testing Your View

People can be reluctant to share their concerns candidly. They might not even be aware that the issues are up for debate. Having a great test question can help uncover blind spots and innovative solutions from those with different perspectives on the situation.

Review the list of test statements. Create two new test questions and record them in the space provided.

- Is there a better way to make sense of this?
- I am more interested in making an informed decision than in winning or being right, so if I've got a blind spot about this issue, please help me see it.
- Where do you see this going wrong, and who else should we bring into the conversation to make sure we are aware of all the risks?
- I don't want my preconceived notions to get in the way of making the best decision, so I really need to hear from people who see it differently.

**Ways to Test My Point of View**

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RESET PAGE

## Speaking with Curiosity

***Toni's point of view statement:***

So, here's my idea. We connect the new sorting machine directly to the stamping press. It'll save a bunch of time. Right now, the production team has to unload everything from the press and then reload it into the sorter.

What could Toni have said to test her perspective?

***Volker's expression of concern:***

I was just wondering, is the sorting machine set up for that configuration? Does anyone know how hot the parts are when they are coming out of the stamping press?

Script a question that Toni could have asked to inquire into Volker's point of view.

## Expressing Curiosity

1. Review the challenging conversation you identified in the LAUNCH assignment and refer to the position and expression of thinking behind it that you created on page 4. Script a few questions you could use to test your position for the conversation.

2. Imagine how others might react to your idea, and then create a script for how you would inquire for further insight about their perspectives.

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RESET PAGE

# Conversational Capacity® Worksheet

Briefly describe the situation or topic to be discussed, and what are you hoping to achieve:

## Catch It, Name It, and Tame It

| What about the conversation might trigger your need to minimize or win? | What about the conversation might cause *others* to need to minimize or win? |
|---|---|

## Maintain a Learning-Focused Mindset

Refocus on learning by keeping these three questions in mind during the conversation:

1. What am I seeing that others are missing?
2. What might others be seeing that I am missing?
3. What might we all be missing?

## Candor Skills

☐ Position

Write a clear, concise, and compelling position statement for the conversation.

☐ Thinking

Outline the thinking that supports your current position.

## Curiosity Skills

☐ Test

Write a few questions you could use to test your current perspective.

☐ Inquire

How might the person respond to your test and how would you inquire into their perspective to gain further insight?

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RESET PAGE

## My Action Plan

What is one thing I will do to increase my awareness of my need to minimize or win?

What is one thing I will do to cultivate a learning-focused mindset?

Which skills will I focus on to increase my conversational capacity?

What important issues will I address, using my new skills?

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### Your MASTER Assignments

1. Schedule and conduct a challenging conversation, within the next two weeks, with someone you work with using the **Conversational Capacity worksheet**.
2. Maintain a **Trigger Journal** to identify the situations, issues, and behaviors that trigger you out of the sweet spot and overwhelm your best intentions.
3. Use the **At a Glance** booklet and your MASTER tools to share what you learned today with a colleague, friend, or family member.
4. Schedule a time to review and adjust your **Action Plan** so you're continually pushing your conversational capacity to higher and higher levels.


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